

# Romans

The Obedience of Faith  
Chapter 12-16

<https://tinyurl.com/RomeGospel>

<https://tinyurl.com/TeachTheWord>

# Faith, Hope, and Love

## The Outline - Review

### ROMANS – Concentric Outline

- A 1:1–17 Gospel (Obedience of Faith)
- B 1:18–3:20 Humanity under sin
  - C 3:21–5:21 Justification
    - D 6–8 New life in Christ
      - E 9–11 Israel and God's purposes
    - D' 12–13 New life practiced
  - C' 14–15 Justification lived in community
- B' 15:14–33 Gospel ministry
- A' 16 Doxology (Ex: Obedience of Faith)

# Purposes of the Gospel

## The Obedience of Faith

*“Through him we have received grace and **our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith** among all the Gentiles on behalf of his name.” (Romans 1:5)*

*“...but now is disclosed, and through the prophetic scriptures has been made known to all the nations, according to the command of the eternal God, **to bring about the obedience of faith**” (Romans 16:26)*

### What is “the Obedience of Faith”? Possibilities...

1. **Obedience that comes from Faith (fruit?)**
  1. The obedience that faith produces.
2. **Obedience which consists of Faith (ingredient?)**
  1. *“But not all have obeyed the good news...” (Romans 10:16)*
3. **Faithful Obedience (different?)**
  1. *“The righteous by faith will live.” (Romans 1:17)*

**What did Obedience of the Law produce?**

**What does Obedience of Faith produce?**

Romans suggests that faith and obedience are inseparable aspects of the same response to God.

**Notice how Paul frames the entire letter:**

*“through whom we have received grace and our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles...” (Romans 1:5, NET)*

**And at the conclusion:**

*“...according to the command of the eternal God to bring about the obedience of faith.” (Romans 16:26, NET)*

*This phrase forms an inclusio around the entire epistle. Paul begins and ends Romans with “the obedience of faith.”*

*That means Romans itself should probably be read through this lens.*

“Look, the one whose desires are not upright will faint from exhaustion, but the person of integrity will live because of his faithfulness.” (**Habakkuk 2:4**)

“For the righteousness of God is revealed in the gospel from faith to faith, just as it is written, “***The righteous by faith will live.*”**” (**Romans 1:17**)

**What is “the obedience of faith”?**

There are several possibilities.

#### 1. Obedience that comes from faith

This is the most common Protestant interpretation.

- *Faith is the root.*
- *Obedience is the fruit.*

The meaning becomes:

- “the obedience that faith produces.”

This is true, but I think Romans says more.

## **2. Obedience which consists of faith**

Paul sometimes speaks of believing as an act of obedience.

- For example:
- “But not all have obeyed the good news...” (Romans 10:16)

Paul then quotes Isaiah:

- “Lord, who has believed our report?”

Notice the parallel:

- Obeyed the gospel.
- Believed the message.

To refuse faith is to disobey.

To believe is to obey.

In this sense, *faith itself is an act of submission to God’s testimony.*

## **3. Faithful obedience**

This may come closest to Habakkuk’s original meaning.

- The Hebrew *emunah* often means:
- *faithfulness*
- *fidelity*
- *steadfast loyalty*

# The Just Shall Live by Faith

## Reconsidering Habakkuk 2:4

*“Look, the one whose desires are not upright will faint from exhaustion, but the person of integrity will live because of his faithfulness.” (Habakkuk 2:4)*

*“For the righteousness of God is revealed in the gospel from faith to faith, just as it is written, **“The righteous by faith will live.”**” (Romans 1:17)*

### Faithful Obedience

This may come closest to Habakkuk's original meaning.

- faithfulness
- fidelity
- steadfast loyalty

### **The Just shall live by a believing loyalty.**

Habakkuk's contrast is between:

- the proud soul
- the faithful soul
- The proud man follows himself.
- The righteous man follows God.

### **Thus, faith and obedience are not two separate categories.**

- They are two perspectives on the same reality.

## **The Just Shall Live by Faith, and the Unjust Chaldeans Will Die (2:4)**

Because the **soul** of the king of Babylon was lifted up with pride, he would die, but the godly remnant of Israel would **live by . . . faith**. Verse 4c is quoted three times in the NT. The three parts of the verse—the just—shall live—by faith, go well with the emphases of the three contexts where they appear: [Rom 1:17](#) emphasizes "the just"; [Gal 3:11](#) emphasizes "faith"; [Heb 10:38](#) emphasizes "shall live." The literal rendering in Habakkuk's context, is "By his faith the just shall live." It could also be paraphrased "the justified-by-faith-one shall live."

## **Reconsidering Habakkuk 2:4**

I would now revise the summary of Habakkuk's influence.

Previously I emphasized:

- The Just shall live by faith.

Now I would emphasize:

- The Just shall live by faithful trust.

Or perhaps:

- The Just shall live by believing loyalty.

Habakkuk's contrast is between:

- the proud soul
- the faithful soul

**The proud man follows himself.**

**The righteous man follows God.**

Thus faith and obedience are not two separate categories.

They are two perspectives on the same reality.

### **3. Faithful obedience**

This may come closest to Habakkuk's original meaning.

The Hebrew *emunah* often means:

- faithfulness
- fidelity
- steadfast loyalty

**Thus the righteous person is not merely someone who trusts God intellectually.**

**He is someone whose trust expresses itself in faithful allegiance.**

The distinction is subtle but important.

- Biblical faith is not merely believing that God exists.
- It is entrusting oneself to Him.
- And entrusting oneself necessarily changes one's conduct.

# The Just Shall Live by Faith

## God's Reconsidering Romans 12-16

### Instead of asking:

- What does faith produce?

### Paul may be asking:

- What does faith look like when lived?

### Romans 12

- Faith presents itself as a living sacrifice.
- Faith serves.
- Faith loves.
- Faith blesses enemies.

*These are not additions to faith. They are faith embodied.*

### Romans 13

- Faith submits to God's ordained authority.
- Faith pays its obligations.
- Faith loves its neighbor.

*Again, this is not faith plus obedience. This is faith expressing its true nature.*

# The Just Shall Live by Faith

## God's Reconsidering Romans 12-16

### Romans 14

- Faith respects conscience.
- Faith refuses to judge fellow servants of God.
- Faith trusts God enough to leave judgment in His hands.

### Romans 15

- Faith bears the weak.
- Faith sacrifices personal rights.
- Faith seeks unity.

### Romans 16

- Faith remains loyal to apostolic truth.
- Faith recognizes faithful laborers.
- Faith rejects false teaching.

*Romans 12-16 is not merely a list of consequences that happen after faith. It is a description of faith itself in action.*



# The Obedience of Faith

## Israel's Failure Revisited (Romans 9-11)

Many readers frame the issue as:

- Israel pursued works.
- Gentiles pursued faith.

Paul's point seems deeper.

- Israel often sought covenant blessing while resisting God's word.

Consider **Romans 10:16**:

- *"But not all have obeyed the good news."*

Again, Paul equates believing and obeying.

- The fundamental issue was not merely a lack of intellectual faith.
- It was a refusal to submit to God's righteousness.
- *"For ignoring the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking instead to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's righteousness." (Romans 10:3)*

## What is the opposite of faith? Unbelief?

### Israel's Failure Revisited

This adjustment is especially important in Romans 9-11.

Notice the key word: **submit**.

- The opposite of faith is not merely unbelief.
- The opposite of faith is self-rule.
- This fits **Habakkuk** perfectly.
- *The proud man trusts himself.*
- *The righteous man entrusts himself to God.*

# The Obedience of Faith

## God's Romans, Galatians, and Hebrews Revisited

With “*the obedience of faith*” in view, the three books become even more unified.

### Romans

- Who are the righteous?
- Those who have submitted to God's righteousness through faithful trust.

### Galatians

- What is obedient faith?
- Not merely belief.
- Faith working through love (**Galatians 5:6**).
- Faithful allegiance to Christ rather than reliance on fleshly achievement.

### Hebrews

- What does it mean to live by faith?
- Persevering loyalty.
- The heroes of **Hebrews 11** did not merely hold correct beliefs.
- They obeyed.
- Their faith was visible because it acted.

### Hebrews

What does it mean to live by faith?

- Persevering loyalty.

The heroes of Hebrews 11 did not merely hold correct beliefs.

They obeyed.

- Noah built.
- Abraham left.
- Moses chose.
- Israel crossed.
- Rahab received.

Their faith was visible because it acted.

## Conclusion

### God's Purposes Will not Fail

If Romans is framed by “*the obedience of faith*” (1:5; 16:26), then **Romans 12-16** should not primarily be viewed as a section on works that follow faith.

Rather, it is Paul's portrait of what faith actually is.

- The faith that justifies is not mere mental assent.
- It is trusting submission to God.
- It is believing allegiance to Christ.
- It is the kind of faith that offers the body as a living sacrifice, loves enemies, submits to God-ordained authority, serves fellow believers, bears the weak, preserves unity, and remains faithful to the gospel.

In that sense, **Habakkuk 2:4**, **Romans 1:5**, and **Romans 12-16** all converge on a single idea:

***The righteous person lives by a faith that obeys because it trusts, and trusts because it has surrendered itself to God. Faith and obedience are not rivals in Paul's thought; they are inseparable expressions of covenant loyalty to the God who saves.***